

Let's say you buy a bargain black blazer at the Gap for \$100. It'll probably stay in style for a season and pill and fade after dry cleaning it five to ten times. So in the course of twenty years of professional use, you'll purchase a new black blazer every two years, say, for a total of \$1,000—assuming the price never goes higher than \$100. Using the math above, you could say my mother's jacket, purchased for \$500 more than twenty years earlier, saved her \$500. But here's the real value: The perpetually fashionable Chanel blazer would fetch about \$1,000 today, according to vintage clothing collectors I've consulted.

So who saved more money? You, with your \$100 blazer purchased every two years for twenty years, at the cost of \$1,000? Or my mother, who bought one jacket, once, at a price of \$500, wore it for twenty years, then sold it for \$1,000? I want you to know this is coming from a man who balks at a designer price tag. I can't believe how much good-quality clothes cost. And I also want to be very clear that *I'm not advocating that you go out and buy Chanel if you can't afford it*. But I am asking you, with everything you buy, to *consider value over impulse*. I am asking you to examine all your purchases and begin to treat everything you buy as an investment. Everything. Even a blazer. I want you to start thinking about quality and the potential resale value of every single purchase you make. It's a good discipline that will cut down on a lot of impulse and redundant spending.

That's what Georgette did. Incidentally, that's what my wife, Linda, does, too. We went to a black-tie function recently, and she pulled out a dress she's had for more than ten years. It's a classic cut, beautifully made, the kind of silhouette that never goes out of style. She's gotten a lot of use out of it. And while my mother bought some of the most beautiful and expensive clothes I've ever seen, almost none of what she bought lost much of its value or stylishness over time. Her closet was well curated. She never bought too much or overspent. She was a smart shopper. Incidentally, my daughter, Savannah, has become a vintage clothing hound. She buys a lot of great pieces secondhand. I like to think she inherited her unique style from her mother and her frugality from her grandmother.

In 2008, my beloved mother passed away. It was devastating and unexpected: a heart attack followed by a stroke on the operating